disengage or withdraw from the freezing heights on the Saltoro range, provided the Pakistanis agreed to authenticate the existing ground positions on the maps. This was primarily due to the trust deficit between the two countries, which has been exacerbated by the Pakistani misadventure in Kargil in 1999. The Pakistani side did not agree to authenticate the present positions, and hence the talks ended on the first day itself. During my tenure as ADGMO, I also accompanied the then defence minister, George Fernandes, to Siachen in 1998. He was one of the few ministers who made a number of visits to these forbidding heights, and with his support, we were able to do a lot to improve the living conditions of soldiers serving there, specially the medical facilities.

Subsequently, on 23 November 2003, both sides agreed to extend the ceasefire along the AGPL in the Siachen area too. This truce has held since then.

As the army chief, I accompanied Prime Minister Manmohan Singh on his visit to the glacier on 12 June 2005. He was the first prime minister to visit the glacier. He called for a peaceful resolution of the problem and made an appeal to make it a 'mountain of peace'. We discussed various dimensions of this issue during this visit. When asked for my views, I had no hesitation in stating that the army was ready for disengagement of forces to fall-back positions, in a phased manner. However, I strongly recommended that this step should only be taken once the Pakistanis agreed to authenticate the present positions. Without doing so, there was every possibility that they might renege from the agreement, grab some of our vacated positions, and then claim that they had always been there!

Further, it is my considered opinion that whenever an agreement is reached and a disengagement and redeployment of forces has to take place, it should be in phases and to positions from where neither side would have an unfair advantage of being able to occupy the area previously held by the other side. Any violation of the agreement by either side should allow the other side to take measures as considered necessary to have the status quo ante restored. In 1989, a proposed agreement for the two militaries to